

BEFORE

Growing populations in Europe in the 16th–17th centuries led to the search for new lands.

CONQUISTADORS

The Americas were the greatest attraction for European settlers. Within 50 years of its discovery in 1492 << 228–29, Spanish conquistadors (conquerors) had occupied more than 1 million square miles (2.6 million km²) of the new continent and named it “New Spain” << 230–31.

EXPLORERS OF AFRICA

In 1652 the Dutch founded a **settlement** at Cape Town, southern Africa, to provision their ships. Mungo Park, a Scot, then **explored** the Niger Valley in 1796–1805. Others, such as David Livingstone, soon followed << 320–21.

PIONEERS IN NORTH AMERICA

Spain founded a colony in Florida in 1565, but after their defeat by Britain in 1586 << 260–61, Britain became the **dominant power**. By the end of the 18th century the British had driven the Dutch and the Swedes from North America, and the French from Canada << 296–97. Migration to America gathered pace after the American Revolution << 298–99.

The world in 1900

European influence stretched across the world. Britain, Russia, and France were the preeminent powers, but Portugal, Germany, and Denmark all controlled parts of Africa, Southeast Asia, and South America.



KEY

	Ottoman Empire		Netherlands and possessions
	Britain and possessions		German Empire and possessions
	France and possessions		Russian Empire and possessions
	Denmark and possessions		Japan and possessions
	Spain and possessions		Italy and possessions
	Portugal and possessions		US and possessions



The Imperial World

In the space of 400 years, Europeans transported the civilization of their continent into every corner of the world. Imperialism—empire-building—expanded so rapidly that by 1900, extensive areas of the inhabited world were governed by Europeans.

Many factors drove imperial expansion. The newly discovered continents of the world offered huge wealth, for example, but once this was realized, traders preferred to do business under their own administration. When Britain seized South Africa, it was because they wanted to deal with the British, rather than native Africans or the Dutch Afrikaner settlers, called Boers.

These new worlds provided exotic luxuries, such as spice from the Indies, tobacco and silks, and, with the onset of the Industrial Revolution (see pp.292–95), a steady supply of raw materials such as cotton. It also became apparent that they were an abundant source of cheap labor.

Another factor in imperial growth was the political rivalries of the major European powers. French imperial ambitions were designed to restore France's reputation after the crushing defeat in the Franco-Prussian War (see pp.306–07). For Germany, the colonies

were a symbol of prestige. In some cases, colonization was simply a matter of claiming a nation before another power could get there. This was particularly so in the “Scramble for Africa” (see pp.360–61).

There were also strong ideological motives. Many felt it their duty to spread Christianity, believing it was, in the poet Rudyard Kipling's words, the “white man's burden” to “civilize” the native population.

European success

Europeans had the men, money, ships, and guns to succeed in their ambitions, and military superiority helped invading nations to subdue local resistance.

The colonial nations found Australasia and North America sparsely inhabited. But elsewhere, such as India, they

discovered populous nations with sophisticated systems of government already in place. This necessitated a different approach to colonization. Communities of merchants were established, with garrisons to protect them, and only rarely did the colonists take formal control. In India, British control of the country (see pp.352–53) by the British East India Company only occurred after a long period of trading.

Empire and migration

New lands beckoned European settlers. Population pressure at home, combined with improved overseas transport,

19th-century spice box

Throughout history, the country that has controlled the spice trade has been the richest. In the 19th century, Britain's maritime prowess established it as the leading colonial power.



led to large-scale migration. In the 19th century, as the frontier of the US moved west (see pp.310–11), millions arrived from across the Atlantic Ocean. The miseries of the Industrial Revolution led many to emigrate. In Victoria, Australia, the discovery of gold in the 1850s triggered a rise in the population from 76,000 to 540,000 in just ten years. Colonists exported their dress, language, and religions around the globe. Western hairstyles, fashion, and